

Preface

The role, nature, and conduct of the military of the United States are subjects worthy of deep reflection at this juncture in American history. Although our military operates largely out of sight of many of our citizens and even of our leaders much of the time, our military and its role in the world is changing, and the military itself is rapidly evolving along several axes.

Never in American history have we maintained a large all-volunteer (or, perhaps better, all-recruited) military force. In the past, the American military demobilized to very small forces in peacetime and then conscripted forces when large numbers were required for the next major conflict. This is itself a dramatic change in our military. On the one hand, America's military is much more professional, better trained and equipped, and of higher quality than we have ever experienced. On the other hand, unlike large conscripted forces, it is unrepresentative of the society it serves in many respects and, some fear, deeply alienated from that society. For many, our military has become a family business as more and more of its members, especially of the officer corps, are themselves products of military families. Politically, America's military (and especially the officer corps) is overwhelming Republican in its politics. Both of these developments raise concern, if not alarm. Concepts of apolitical military professionalism and service to the whole of American society require rearticulation and reexamination in these changed circumstances.

In parallel with those social developments in the military, there have been dramatic changes in the technology with which that military is equipped. Precision munitions in more and more weapons systems radically change the moral symmetry of risk in combat. Unmanned platforms are rapidly proliferating that alter that symmetry even further. Electronic communications, satellite imagery, and computer technology provide a comprehensive awareness of the battlefield and work together to make the US military effective in ways no other military on the planet can even approximate. These developments raise new ethical questions about the

appropriate use and limits of such capabilities. Each new development raises questions, many of them unforeseen, about the limits and proper use of those systems.

Cumulatively, these evolutionary changes in the role and nature of our military make the United States the sole remaining superpower (or, if one prefers, “hyperpower”) on the planet. This fact, too, raises fundamental questions about the international system and the role of the United States in it. How, for example, do we combine the reality of American uniqueness with the concept of sovereign equality of states that forms the bedrock of the Westphalian international system and the United Nations? Especially in the Global War on Terrorism (GWOT) in which we are now engaged, how do rules of international relations accommodate the twin realities of American uniqueness and having an adversary that does not take the form of a state?

This book is an exploration of many dimensions of these issues.

Introduction

The Sole Remaining Superpower

Imagine this scenario: For fifty years, a grand voluntary alliance of independent states has held the line against an imperial expansionist state that has swallowed all in its path up to the alliance's border. The hegemonic intentions of this state have been held in check by a few crucial victories of the alliance.

The defensive alliance began as an association of independent and relatively equal states united in a defense pact. Each member state, in proportion to its economic and political power, contributed to the defense against the common threat.

But over the decades, as the threat to the alliance grew less palpable, fewer and fewer member states were willing voluntarily to allocate the physical resources necessary to keep their fighting capability high. Nor were they willing to spend the money needed to preserve the alliance's credibility and high state of readiness.

In the face of a general distaste for alliance adventures, one state took the lead. It argued for a large, rapidly deployable, and highly mobile force, capable of quickly meeting any hostile actions directed at the alliance. It alone maintained the political will to maintain such a force in being and a unified command structure prepared for any contingency that might arise.

As her allies abdicated responsibility for collective security, this state grew from being a "first among equals" to being the sole major power. Increasingly, other member states of the alliance preferred to make their contribution by granting basing rights to the leading state.

The smaller states found these basing support arrangements for the major power more palatable to their political systems than sustaining the trained and ready fighting units from their own states that had been the foundation of the alliance in its earlier form.

Initially happy to be freed of the burden of sustaining their own forces, the lesser states of the alliance came to place all their reliance on the military might of the sole remaining superpower. In the unlikely event that the distant hegemon should once again threaten the region, or that small-scale emergencies should arise in the alliance's area of responsibility, the alliance superpower's military would cope with the problem. For all parties, this "arrangement of convenience" seemed for a time to be acceptable all around.

As the superpower grew and the member states waned in capability, the superpower was more and more in a position not merely to receive the voluntary support of the member states, but increasingly to pressure, and finally to demand and coerce, coalition support for its military power. But, the superpower felt justified even in the coercion of former allies, for she sincerely believed that she alone correctly perceived the threat and that her actions genuinely served the common good of the alliance.

Visitors to the superpower's territories from alliance states could not but perceive its growing economic superiority and dominance; they could not miss the growing gap in wealth and cultural dominance of the superpower over their world. Money contributed for common defense was used to build public buildings of great grandeur in the superpower, and supported its vital cultural and artistic life (exported, with increasing resentment, throughout the alliance's territory).

One traditionally difficult alliance member began to complain that the gap between the superpower and all her former allies was approaching a point of no return. Unless something was done, and done soon, the superpower would emerge as the absolute and incontestably dominant power in their world as far into the future as the eye could see.

Eventually, sparked by agitation by this state, a segment of the old alliance came to see the superpower itself as the major threat to the peace and independence of the member states. While the potential threat of the old hegemon lurked in the background, the daily reality of the superpower's increasingly imperious demands

was clear and present. Indeed, from the allies' perspective, her demands seemed to grow in inverse proportion to the visibility of the threat.

The scenario just sketched is, of course, the summary of the growing power of Athens in the lull following the Persian Wars. The events set the stage for the war with the former allies of Athens, the Peloponnesian League. It incited the struggles among the allies of Athens, the Delian League, and the war between the Delian League and a resurgent alliance centered on Sparta, events narrated in that classic military history and strategy, the history of the Peloponnesian War by the Athenian historian Thucydides.

While there were many small incidents and provocations leading to the war, its great chronicler, Thucydides, reduced them to one: "The growth of the power of Athens, and the alarm which this inspired in Sparta, made war inevitable" (1.23.5).¹ Thucydides wrote his work to be "a possession for all time," and indeed it is.

Any resemblance between that scenario and the situation of the United States and NATO following the withdrawal of the Soviet Union from the world stage is far from coincidental.

The conduct of Athens toward her former allies, her supreme confidence that she faced no peer in the foreseeable future, and her strategic and operational blunders once a segment of her former allies took up arms against her combined to bring about her utter destruction.

Far too often, when Thucydides' work is taught at all in professional military education or in standard political science and international relations courses, it is taught extremely superficially. How many times has the Melian Dialogue, ripped completely from its context, been used merely to illustrate "realism" as a theory of international relations?

The full richness of *A History of the Peloponnesian War* can only be appreciated by means of a thorough reading of the work, which follows events from the rise of Athens to imperial power to its final catastrophic fall, in many ways at her own hand. In that larger reading, the Melian Dialogue is but a cautionary tale to show how an imperial power can overlay its hand.

Thucydides' *History* is a classical Greek tragedy of tragic flaws and hubris. Athens plays the protagonist and the Melian protest of the injustice of her action is equivalent to the chorus in a

Sophoclean play, warning the protagonist of the folly and danger of the course she has set for herself. From the perspective of one knowing of the whole sweep of the war, the Melians were, in fact, giving wise strategic counsel and realistic advice for the long term. They argued for commonly accepted and fair international standards of action, observed by all, even by the strong.

The story of the fall of Athens can illuminate much about the besetting sins and temptations inherent in being the sole remaining superpower in the world. Indeed, this book will argue that Athens and her conduct during the period of her ascendancy form a parallel narrative well worth pondering in our own present historical circumstances. This historical analogue may provide insight into the predictable temptations of unmatched power in periods of low-intensity strategic rivalry.

The Roots of Athenian Ascendancy

Athens did not set out to be the superpower in her world. The defeat of the Persians in 490 BCE, and again in 480–479 BCE, had been accomplished by a Panhellenic alliance, that combine the renowned Spartan skill at land warfare and leadership, with Athenian naval prowess. The conclusion of that war left the Greek alliance deployed over vast stretches of the Mediterranean and united in the Delian League through voluntary contributions to a fund for the common defense at the sacred island of Delos.

The deep and widely held cultural commitment to the polis, the autonomous city-state, as the foundation of Greek society was a barrier to maintaining unity over such wide-ranging territory. Even Athens, although she was dominant over many other city-states, seemed never to conceive of forming coherent political institutions commensurate with the scope of her power. From the beginning to the end of the conflict, Athenians thought of themselves purely in terms of loyalty to their city. Other cities were thought of either as allies, enemies, or providers of tribute. The other Greek cities shared Athens's love for the particular political unit of the polis with equal enthusiasm.

At the conclusion of the Persian War, the alliance was still led by Sparta. The alliance asked Athens to lead it however, when the

Spartan king Pausanias disgraced himself in command by his arrogance and his favoritism toward the Spartan troops in the alliance.² Sparta quickly reverted to her conservative ways and pulled back to tend to her own city and traditions. Athens, by contrast, had a vast navy, and remained engaged in both military and economic terms with the entire Mediterranean area accessible by sea. Athenian wealth depended on freedom of navigation and trade, and Athenian naval power was necessary for the maintenance of both. The successor alliance to that formed to defeat the Persians, the Delian League, emerged with Athens at its head.

Thus did Athens become the undisputed head and leader of the Mediterranean world. Only the loosely structured Peloponnesian “league” remained outside, and it was weakly organized and hardly a match for the growing power of Athens.³

Although the Delian League was initially a voluntary alliance and, conducted business by voting of the member states, Athens quickly came to dominate it. Finally, in 454/453 BCE, the pretense of equality among the states was dropped entirely. The treasury moved from Delos to Athens, and Athens claimed one sixtieth of the annual income of the fund for her own use—funds that were used to build the magnificent buildings of Athens and to pay citizens for public service.

Athens had stumbled upon an empire. Ironically, having fought for the independence of the Greek city-states in the face of the forthrightly imperial power of Persia, Athens herself took up the model of empire and recipient of tribute payment from subordinate states. So having fought for the independence of the Greeks from imperial tyranny, she herself came to play Persia’s role—but without the political system to administer an empire effectively. Indeed, although the scope of the strategic demands of Athens was imperial, one may question whether an affiliation of nominally independent cities could ever achieve the unity required for Athens’s strategic purposes.

While still mouthing the national values of democratic government, open and tolerant social practices, and the flourishing of the arts and sciences through unfettered thought and exploration, Athens increasingly had to play the role of oppressor. As the Athenians said of themselves, “That empire we acquired, not by violence, but because you [Spartans] were unwilling to prosecute

to its conclusion the war against the barbarian, and because the allies attached themselves to us and spontaneously asked us to assume command" (1.75).

Athenians were quite capable of self-delusion about their geopolitical situation, and believed that the beauty and cultural achievements of their city and its democratic institutions justified its superior status. Because of their pride in their city's accomplishments, they were tempted to exempt themselves from ordinary standards of fairness, or even consistency with their own espoused values. But it was the hero of Thucydides' tale, Pericles, who would tell Athens the unvarnished truth: "[W]hat you hold is, to speak somewhat plainly, a tyranny; to take it perhaps was wrong, but to let it go is unsafe" (2.63.2).

Following Pericles' death early in the developing war between Athens and the Peloponnesian alliance of states centered on Sparta, the political leadership of Athens became less and less sure. Athens lost the coherent strategic vision Pericles had provided, overextended herself in too many theaters of conflict, and missed opportunities for favorable peace settlements through foolish pride after successes. Finally, catastrophically, Athens committed vast resources to a failed attempt to take and control Sicily and experienced a military defeat from which she never fully recovered.

All parties attempted to augment their power by deals with the Persians; and, while the Spartan alliance "won" the war in the short run, it meant the end of Greek civilization as it had flourished in the classical period. It was replaced by the period of true empires: the Persian empire, then the Hellenistic empire under Alexander the Great and his successors, and finally and most lastingly, the Roman Empire.

So in less than a hundred years, Athens and all of Greece went from the glory of defeating the Persians at Marathon and Salamis to the disgrace of seeing the destruction of her form of life. The art, literature, and philosophy that form the foundation of Western civilization are products of that "one brief shining moment" of Athenian ascendancy. The failure of Athens to understand and manage her strategic situation in this period led to her own destruction and opened the way to a new age of imperial conquest by other civilizations.

Was this historical course inevitable? Could Athens have used her unprecedented political and military status in the Greek world

to create a more fortunate outcome? Are there lessons from Athenian experience that make Thucydides' painstaking chronicle of the demise of Athens truly the "possession for all time" (1.22) he intended? What are the lessons for grand strategy one can gain from reflection on Athens's historical experience?

In the next sections of this chapter, I will attempt to extract the main themes and blunders Thucydides' history points up as predictable traps for major powers at the height of their supremacy.

Don't Make Your Own Enemies

Athens emerged from the Persian War as a heroic and honored member of the Greek world. With astonishing boldness and courage, Athenians had abandoned their city en masse to Persian occupation and set sail for Salamis, where they decisively defeated the Persian fleet and forced Persian withdrawal. As we have already seen, after the disgrace of the Spartan Pausanias, the Athenians were invited by their allies to take the lead of the Delian League.

In the period following, Athens planted colonies throughout the Mediterranean and used her fleet to ensure the safety of a far-flung trading network that brought Greece to a new level of prosperity and peace. Athenian culture and learning flourished, making this short period of her history one of the pivotal moments in the development of human culture. Socrates and Plato, Sophocles and Euripides, Phidias and Pericles walked her streets and gave Western culture the foundations for learning and government of which we are still the heirs.

How, then, were they able so to alienate their former allies that within fifty years, the representatives of many Greek cities would meet and perceive Athens herself as their greatest threat? How can such cultural and political triumph sow the seeds of its own destruction? The conduct of Athens echoes of U.S. conduct in the current conflict:

[W]e must ask how the coalition that Secretary of State Powell has been skillfully building is being seen by his colleagues in the government. Do they see it as a partnership in which our allies will not only provide various forms of

support, but also take part in the major decisions? As often before in NATO, the danger is that we will look at our allies as junior partners in our firm, asked to supplement our forces and to pay for the common good.⁴

The naval power of Athens—both her own forces and those she commanded by means of the Delian League—was superior, not only to her nearest rivals individually, but to all of the rest of Greece collectively. The Peloponnesian alliance had only Corinth as a major maritime power and fell far short of the Delian League's unity of command and control.⁵

As a trading nation, however, much of that power was used to prevent piracy and to maintain freedom of navigation that was very much to the benefit of all of maritime Greece. Properly used, therefore, Athenian military superiority might well have worked for the common good of Greece, and Athens may be somewhat forgiven for seeing its power in those terms, even as other cities came to resent and then fear it. Good strategic leadership might well have found a way for Athens to emerge as the natural and commonly accepted leader of an expanding and ever more prosperous Greek civilization embracing the whole of the Mediterranean world.

But Athens found ways of pursuing ever-greater superiority that could only inspire fear and suspicion in other states. The main and most natural axis of Athenian expansion and dominance was, of course, to the east. For many years, Athens was indeed content to colonize and dominate the islands and coast of the eastern Mediterranean—a large area that gave it plenty of scope for virtually indefinite expansion.

The other significant naval power in the Greek world, Corinth, had its own sphere of influence and navigation on the western side of the Greek world and along the sea lanes to Italy and Sicily. Not content with this traditional and somewhat natural division, Athens began to make encroachments that Corinth could not fail to find threatening. First, it succeeded in removing Megara from the Spartan alliance, garrisoned it, and built long walls that made its ports virtually immune to attack. Then it fortified a base at Naupactus settled by refugees from conflict with Sparta. The net effect of these moves was to place Athens in the position to threaten dominance of the

Crisaeon Gulf, Corinth's access lane to the sea. As Thucydides remarks, "This was the principal cause of the Corinthians conceiving such a deadly hatred against Athens" (1.103[4]).

Needless to say, Athens perceived its actions not as threats to the security of Corinth or any other state, but merely as part of an indefinite and in principle limitless strategy of expanding empire and security arrangements. Her moves seemed to her natural and perhaps even for the common good of Greece in giving her access of the western part of the Greek world and, potentially, access to alternative sources of grain, including grain exports from Sicily.

Her pursuit of unilateral military dominance and economic self-sufficiency, however, inevitably was perceived as aggressive, and as a threat to other states' vested economic and strategic interests. It may be true, of course, that at the moment of its expansion Athens possessed the strength to make these moves with relative impunity. But as Thucydides tells us, that impunity was only of a short-term nature and created the animosity that would ripen into Corinthian agitation for rearmament and formation of an alliance of sufficient strength to oppose and contain Athenian expansion. Athens's limitless pursuit of absolute and unilateral security was the seedbed of absolute insecurity. It inevitably generated its own "arms race," as other states strove to resist the complete dominance of Athens.

After the Persian occupation of Athens and the destruction of her city wall during the Persian invasion, Sparta had actually urged Athens to remain unwallled—a kind of arms control regime in which both states would forgo maximal self-defense in the name of retaining relative parity through mutual vulnerability.

Instead, Athens dispatched Themistocles, the hero of Salamis, to Sparta so that, by his delay and duplicity, they might have opportunity secretly to rebuild their city wall. Themistocles then urged the Athenians to build the "long walls" from Athens all the way to her port at Pireaus, giving her almost invulnerable city walls and secure access to her port and fleet at all times (1.90–91). In short, rather than being willing to trade some degree of vulnerability for stability and order, Athens's single-minded pursuit of her own absolute security came to breed instability and fear.

Now Athens had achieved virtual invulnerability. Her city had elaborate defensive walls; her port was immune from attack; her

capabilities for import and trade were secure from all disruption, and, if all else failed, she possessed the capacity she demonstrated at Salamis to evacuate the city. But again, her quest of security had the inevitable effect of threatening all other states.

This is a classic trap for a superpower. Because it can pursue its own vision of security without restraint and without the need to negotiate, it runs the risk of actions that, while sensible from within its own strategic frame, have the effect of creating its own enemies. They emerge from framing its strategic problem too narrowly and over too short a time frame. Actions that are taken only in light of their short-term strategic advantage and oblivious to their inevitable consequences in the behavior of other rational actors in the strategic environment are the result.

What issues, in our own strategic environment, might we reflect upon in light of this historical analogue? Clearly, NATO expansion bears many of the same marks as Athens's encroachment into Corinth's strategic backyard. Megara, Pegea, and the refugee-inhabitants of Naupactus were all former inhabitants and allies of Corinth and Sparta. All sought alliance with Athens to be more secure against continued friction with Corinth and Sparta.

From Athens's perspective, welcoming them into alliance could only seem an excellent idea. They were new voluntary allies, eager to affiliate with Athens and the Delian League; they gave Athens access to new markets, new areas of influence traditionally beyond her sphere. They gave Athens military basing privileges in areas where she had interests, but had not been historically present. And at the moment, neither Sparta nor Corinth had the means to resist effectively Athenian expansion. From the Athenian perspective, her new alliances and forward bases would give her military strength that, even if Corinth or Sparta should wish to resist, she would by then be invincible.

But it was precisely these moves that made Corinth the implacable enemy of Athens. They caused Corinth to begin the drumbeat of resistance that would, in time, bring Sparta out of her seclusion and into open conflict with Athens as the head of a great alliance.

It may, then, provide some perspective on NATO expansion if one thinks of Russia and perhaps other parts of the former Soviet Union as the analogues to Corinth and Sparta. Do we, like Athens, fail to think through the downstream strategic consequences of

alliances and military encroachments on powers that, for the moment, are incapable of resisting? Should it really surprise us if they feel threatened by those moves? Should we be surprised that our assurances of purely benign intent and motivations for the common good ring less true in Moscow than they do in Washington? Do we think through the more remote, but not unforeseeable, consequence of moves that make strategic sense in the short range, but induce fears and anxieties that may come back to haunt us?

A similar case can be made regarding Athens's pursuit of invulnerability in the construction of its walls and the long walls to its port, the Pireaus. The rhetoric of invulnerability surrounding National Missile Defense makes an interesting parallel. Surely defensive capability, pursued beyond a certain point, is as strategically destabilizing as augmented offensive capability. Sparta well knew that an Athens that could not be attacked by land made it, in regard to a land power such as Sparta, virtually invulnerable—as did Pericles when open warfare broke out. Thus his counsel to the Athenians during the first, Archidamian, phase of the war to remain behind the walls and let Spartan armies exhaust themselves in strategically meaningless forays into the Attic countryside.

Since others saw Athens's walls as a threat, giving her an offensive capability to act with impunity, perhaps we should be less surprised that allies as well as former adversaries are not convinced of the purity of our National Missile Defense aspirations. Sparta's proposal that Athens remain unwallled was, for its time and place, a rough equivalent of the ABM treaty. Athens's insistence of maximal self-defense was much like our threat to abrogate the stability of mutual vulnerability in the name of unilateral maximal self-defense. It is not difficult to foresee that National Missile Defense may well prove to be equally destabilizing and equally likely to precipitate arms races and organized resistance. One might also note the strategic irrationality of devoting large resources to preventing small numbers of missile attacks when covert delivery of the same weapons by Ryder truck remains a perfectly good alternative.

In the ancient world, as in ours, stability is achieved only at two points of the spectrum: where rough parity prevails and where absolute unilateral dominance is achieved on the model of the Roman Empire. The intermediate position of one rapidly advancing

state in the presence of other states not yet peer competitors, but possessing the resources to oppose that state if they perceive the need to do so, is the most dangerous to manage. In the event, Athens seems to have possessed the will, but not the capability, to achieve absolute dominance in her world. The United States however, appears to lack both the capability and the will to strive for it—leaving aside the question whether it would be justifiable and prudent to do so.

The commercial policies of Athens were another important means by which she alienated her allies and frightened her potential enemies. For example, in 449/448, Athens decreed that all allied states must close their mints and imposed Athenian weights, measures, and coins on the allies.⁶ Similarly, in her Megarian Decree, Athens used withdrawal of access to her markets as a blunt instrument with which to bludgeon states that did not acquiesce in her political and military dominance. Although the details are sketchy, clearly Athens's use of her commercial preeminence in a way that led to the detriment of other states was a major cause of the growing resistance to her empire.⁷

Correspondingly, there is a growing perception in much of the world that the World Bank, the International Monetary Fund, and "free trade" as the United States perceives it are just an extension of imperial dominance. Athens's challenge, like ours, was to make sure that her own growing wealth through trade was a perceived benefit to other Greek states, and not merely an additional weapon in her imperial quest.

Athens exercised a similar arrogance in her legal relations with other members of the Delian League. Athens decreed that all legal disputes between Athens and her allies must be tried in Athenian courts. Not only did this give Athens an obvious advantage but, given the democratic composition of those courts, it was an offense to allied aristocracy that they must be answerable to the Athenian popular will, the *demos*, in legal matters.⁸ Just as the United States wishes to assert unique exemption from the emerging international legal regime of the International Criminal Court, Athens wished to retain its exceptional position among supposedly equal states.

If these assessments are valid, then clear strategic thinking in such environments must give due weight to balance and must take seriously the importance of the ripple effects of unilateral actions

on the stability of the overall international system. Athens's failure to do that instilled fear and reinvigorated an opposing alliance that otherwise would have remained quiescent or, given more sensitive Athenian stewardship, even have joined Athens in a stable and unified Greek world.⁹

Rather than insisting on unilateral security, US abrogation of stable international arrangements (such as the ABM treaty), and US exemption from the International Criminal Court and similar efforts at universal and stable international institutions, we should see how our strategic thought could be informed by Athens's example. If it were, we would turn more to enhancing stability and less to provocative unilateral actions justified from the narrow perspective of the quest of unique defensive and offensive capabilities.

Be Imperial without Being Imperialist

Athens found itself, almost by accident, as an imperial power.¹⁰ The structure of its military, its economy's dependence on freedom of navigation and trade, and the defensive requirements of a still dangerous Persian empire all made Athens's far-flung empire (by ancient standards) worldwide. The strategic question before it was not whether to head an empire, but how to head it.

In this respect also, the situation of Athens bears close resemblance to our own. For the contemporary United States, just as for Athens, "The ideas that there are discreet baskets called 'foreign affairs' and 'domestic affairs' is no longer the case, if indeed it ever was. Increasingly, there are spillover effects, whether what is at stake is drugs, immigration, trade, ideas or email. Terrorism can come to our shores. So, too, can missiles. Fortress America, even if it were desirable, is simply not doable."¹¹

The strategic goal, therefore, is to be imperial without being imperialist, without risking "imperial overstretch," in Paul Kennedy's famous phrase¹². What that means, of course, is that one must use the instruments of national power to help shape the environment and the conduct of the "international community" such that it conforms to national interests. It also means that one must do so in such a way that one does not create enemies by imperialist conduct, and one must use one's resources prudently, and not to exhaust them in futile overreach.

We have already seen the many ways in which Athens created her own enemies. But even this might not have been fatal, had she used her superior power prudently, defeating enemies when necessary, but also co-opting them for her strategic purposes. Even having mismanaged the peace and empire handed her, Athens might still have been victorious strategically had she not overplayed her hand in foolish and strategically ill-advised military adventurism.

The most notorious example of this was the decision to dispatch her fleet for an assault on Sicily. Using the pretense of assisting the Attic population of Sicily, and attempting to counter a very distant threat of Syracuse, the principal city of the island, Athens moved to “order all . . . matters in Sicily as . . . best for the interests of Athens” (6.8.2). From a strategic perspective, such control of Sicily would have given Athens a second reliable source for importation of grain (which she was already importing on a commercial basis alone), a foothold in the western Mediterranean, and an anchor for her westward imperial expansion, bracketing the Peloponnesian alliance.

It fell to Nicias, the “Cassandra”¹³ of Athenian strategy, to point out the foolishness of “grasping at another empire before we have secured the one we already have” (6.10.5). He alone grasped the problem with the enterprise being proposed: “[T]he Sicilians, even if conquered, are too far off and too numerous to be ruled without difficulty” (6.11.1). And Nicias alone proposed the most prudent strategic engagement with Sicily: “The Hellenes in Sicily would fear us most if we never went there at all, and next to this, if after displaying our power we went away again as soon as possible” (6.11.4).

But it was Alcibiades’ speech that swayed the Athenian assembly. He said, “[W]e cannot fix the exact point at which our empire shall stop” (6.18.3), suggesting that even the conquest of Sicily could prove only the stepping-stone on the way to the conquest of Carthage as well.

In short, having gained a respite from war and having had yet another opportunity to negotiate from strength and to shape the international environment to Athens’s liking, Athens chose instead a course of imperialist conquest that resulted in the utter destruction of her fleet and army. “When the news was brought to Athens, for a long while they disbelieved even the most respectable of the soldiers who had themselves escaped from the scene of action and

clearly reported the matter, a destruction so complete not being thought credible” (8.1.1).

At every juncture, Athens overreached and failed to explore diplomatic arrangements that might have given her stability and an international environment to her liking. Although she had experienced strategic setbacks and defeats, at the time of the decision to go to Sicily Athens was very much in a position of strength, and had the opportunity to exploit her strategic advantage. Instead, she again sought military conquest far afield, making joint resistance to her efforts the only course of action available to her opponents. Finally, the combined forces of Syracuse and the Peloponnesian alliance crushed the Athenian forces in Sicily.

Although the conflict recommenced and continued, Athens’ great strategic moment had passed. In every important sense, Athens had defeated herself. Her repeated and stubborn failure to grasp and manage her strategic environment effectively not only bred enemies; it finally squandered her military power itself.

What are the salient analogues between Athens’s experience and our own? When this introduction was first written, it stated: “Obviously, the United States is not likely to send a large fraction of its military off in ill-conceived invasions of distant lands. But this particular course of action of Athens was, I would argue, merely a symptom of a deeper failure of strategic thought that does, indeed, bear important parallels to our situation.” Now that a very large fraction of the U.S. military is apparently going to be in Iraq for a long time, the parallel is unfortunately, even more striking.

The fundamental strategic failure of Athens—and, indeed, of the entire Hellenic world—was the failure to grasp that the political structure of the polis, the sovereign city-state, was no longer adequate to the task of governance or of security in the international environment after the Persian War.

Although the Greek city-states had rallied effectively during that conflict in a military sense, they failed both during and after the war to build enduring political structures to match their military alliance. Athens did correctly perceive the need for a continuing military alliance in the face of the threat of Persia. But rather than building a truly effective “international” (i.e., interpolis) political organization, she converted the Delian League into her own fiefdom.

Had she instead found a way to use her unique power position to bring the economic, cultural, and political benefits of Athenian citizenship to her empire generally, she would have been spared the struggles of her tributaries to break free, and might have gained over time the voluntary affiliation of many of the members of Sparta's alliance as well. She might truly have been in her world the "city set on a hill" and the "light unto the nations" and have lived up to the role Pericles imagined for it: "[A]s a city, we are the school of Hellas" (2.41.1).

The United States, too, is at such a deciding moment. As sole remaining superpower, it too can elect to use that status to pursue and shore up narrowly conceived national interests. But there is no reason to expect the consequences of such behavior to be fundamentally different than those Athens experienced. While of course the degree of historical distance will make the details differ, the fundamental forces of human nature and statecraft are unchanged, and the consequences of a mode of behavior like that of Athens are foreseeable in any geopolitical time and place.

Alternatively, the United States might use this world-historical moment to help to forge the economic, diplomatic, and military structures that can genuinely serve the international common good. Surely Athens had that alternative. The worlds of trade her empire made possible might have continued to enrich the entire Greek world. Her experiments in democratic government, exported to some degree, might have been wedded with effective interpolis structures of government and law that would have stabilized the Greek world to the benefit of all.

Exactly what such structures should be for the United States and how they should be used is an issue of complexity and depth well beyond the scope of this introduction. But if the historical example of the Athenian empire is a useful conceptual model, these are the questions that should be at the center of strategic thought in the United States during this window of historical opportunity.

For example, the failure of Athens to imagine effective and just structures of law and governance larger than the city-state finally rendered her empire unmanageable and threatening to other powers. Had Athens used her political and military dominance as an opportunity to lead her world in the shaping of transnational (i.e., transpolis) governance structures, she might have led her

world into a period of unprecedented peace and prosperity. Instead, as her power grew, she was less and less a leader of an alliance, and more and more dismissive of the legitimate claims and interests of her former allies.

In the contemporary context, the United States faces a world in which it is evident that any number of concerns and issues are no longer effectively addressed solely through the framework of state sovereignty. The United States says it bombs in Kosovo in the name of universal principles, and in the same breath resists all efforts to institutionalize those principles in an international criminal court.¹⁵

Rather than funding and aggressively helping shape and reform the United Nations, the United States tends to give it inadequate resources and support and then complains of the UN's failures.

The United States complains that the Europeans are not bearing their fair share of costs for their own defense and that they lack the will and capability to respond to crises in Europe without United States assistance, but then it resists and threatens when they show evidence of organizing precisely such a capability.

These suggestions are, of course, merely schematic, and the issues are complex. But they do suffice to show ways in which the United States, like Athens, is deeply in love with the inherited international system (in their case, the polis; in ours, the sovereignty of the United States). Just like Athens, the United States finds it difficult to conceive larger international structures that would be fairer to all states and more effective in making its present favorable place in the world less a threat to other states.

It is difficult to say with precision, of course, what those structures should be. If the example of Athens does illuminate the present, it demonstrates that failure to make the conceptual leap when it is in one's power to do so safely can result in policies that are favorable to oneself in the short run, but that such a failure of foresight and imagination has inevitable and foreseeable negative consequences just over the horizon.

Like Athens, the United States finds itself at a moment history hands to few states, and then for only a limited period of time. It is a world-historical moment at which active engagement might well result in a permanent change to the geopolitical landscape of the world. In this book, I will explore the moral directions I believe

these challenges will point us toward and the revisions in our thinking about the nature and role of the profession of arms these challenges will entail for the United States and its military.